

Q+A

A NEW DIRECTION

***Sayani Gupta** sits in the director's chair for the first time with her short, Aasmani, about a powder-blue Fiat and its owner who is trying to save it*

Q. Did you first get the itch to direct while you were studying acting at the Film & Television Institute of India (FTII)?

I opted for FTII because I was interested in how films were made. I was never just an acting student there, and I assisted a lot of seniors in different departments—direction, production design, editing. Making a film was part of this nagging desire that I need to do this. It has been on my mind for 17 years now.

Q. While acting across films and web series, did you keep thinking about directing too?

I've made mental notes all these years of what to do, not to do, who to work with. When season three of *Four More Shots Please!* ended, I approached Rangita Nandy, expressing my interest in directing a few episodes. She said, "Shy, I totally believe you can. But I need to see something you have made." I made *Aasmani* to show people what I was capable of.

Q. A short film is traditionally seen as a stepping stone for filmmakers. Do you hope to direct more?

I love watching short films, acting in them and reading short stories. *Aasmani* is my first baby. There was a lot of learning that happened every single day. I made an accessible film. The idea is to tell more stories and grow with every film.

Q. Do you have a release in mind?

If you make a film, you want people to watch it and the money invested recovered. I don't see making shorts as '*haath saaf kar liya*' (doing for the heck of it). I will approach all OTT platforms. It'd be nice to have a release in theatres alongside a feature or with a bouquet of shorts.

—with Suhani Singh